

Binary form

The word “binary” means having two parts. A musical piece in binary form has two large sections, usually labeled A and B. For this reason, binary form is also known as the AB form.

SEE ALSO

◀ 124–125 Degrees of the scale

◀ 154–155 Repeats

Ternary form

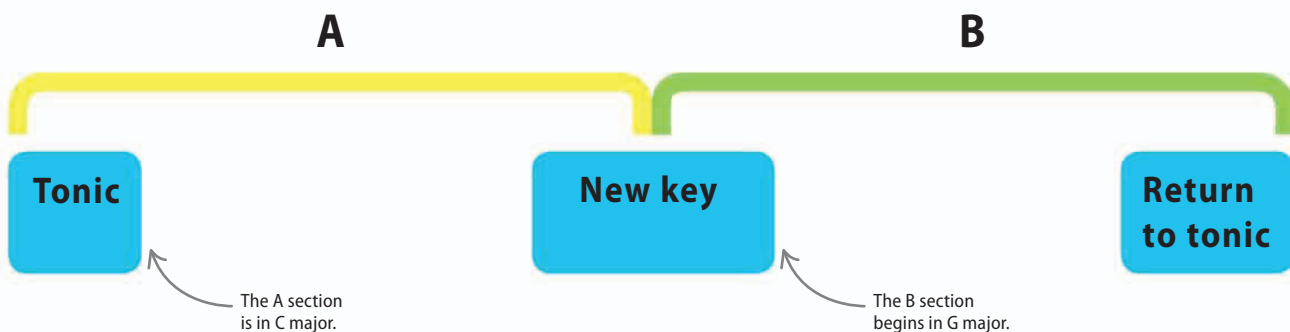
160–161 ▶

How are A and B different?

The A and B parts of a piece in binary form are usually similar in terms of melodic and rhythmic material. The major difference between the two is that the B section modulates, or moves, to a different but related key. If the key of the A section is a major key, usually the B section will modulate to the key of the fifth scale degree, or *sol*—also known as the dominant key.

▽ AB

This diagram shows how a binary piece contains two sections, with a corresponding move from tonic to a closely related key, and then back again. Each portion is repeated, and the B section modulates to the tonic key.



▽ “Yankee Doodle”
In this example, written in F major, the B section starts not in the dominant key (which would be C major), but in the closely related relative minor—D minor.

The diagram shows the musical notation for the first two sections of “Yankee Doodle” in 4/4 time. The A section is in F major and ends with passages of running scales, reinforcing the tonic. The B section is in D minor and ends with a scale degree five or *sol*—cadence in F major.